

SATISFYING UNMET EMOTIONAL NEEDS

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. View self as more independent and capable rather than needy and dependent on -others.
2. Identify and specify unmet emotional needs.
3. Identify self-help actions to meet emotional needs.
4. Make a commitment to begin self-help action to meet emotional needs.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Borderline Personality
- Depression
- Grief/Loss Unresolved
- Intimate Relationship Conflicts
- Low Self-Esteem
- Social Discomfort
- Suicidal Ideation

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

This exercise helps clients focus on their unmet emotional needs. Clients who struggle with dependency, depression, or feelings of inadequacy often develop a sense of helplessness for doing anything to improve their situation. This assignment challenges the client to think about ways that he/she can commit himself/herself to a self-help action plan. The therapist probably will have to guide the client in listing actions he/she could take to improve the probability of getting his/her needs met. But, it is recommended that the client be allowed to struggle with this issue alone before the therapist provides too much assistance. Actually, this assignment becomes a test of the client's dependency on the therapist to do the assignment for him/her.

SATISFYING UNMET EMOTIONAL NEEDS

All human beings have emotional needs that they want to be fulfilled. When these needs are not satisfied, we feel sad, depressed, lonely, hurt, disappointed, or even worthless. This exercise will help you identify and specify what needs of yours are unmet as well as to help you design a plan of action to get your needs met by doing something constructive to help yourself take charge of the satisfaction of your own needs. Too often, people rely on others or life's circumstances to get their needs met and they are disappointed. It is a much healthier approach to do everything you can to assert yourself and arrange your world in such a way that your needs get met through the actions or requests that you make of other people. To be completely dependent on others to meet your needs makes you too vulnerable to hurt and disappointment, and it denies your own capabilities and resources to get your needs met.

Unmet Emotional Needs

1. Review the list of common emotional needs and place an X next to the ones that you feel are not met in your life. There are three blank lines for you to write in any unmet needs of yours that were left off the list.

☐ 1. To feel loved unconditionally by at least a few people.
☐ 2. To get recognition for accomplishments.
☐ 3. To be touched, patted, and hugged affectionately.
☐ 4. To be encouraged to do your best.
☐ 5. To be listened to, understood, and heard.
☐ 6. To feel supported when feeling hurt, weak, or vulnerable.
☐ 7. To be praised and rewarded for your effort to do the right thing.
☐ 8. To be treated with respect even if you disagree with someone.
☐ 9. To be forgiven when you do something wrong.
☐ 10. To feel accepted even with your faults or shortcomings.
☐ 11. To be asked to join others in social gatherings.
☐ 12. To be trusted and believed when telling your side of a story.
☐ 13. To have friends you can trust.

22. _____
23. _____

2. You must not rely entirely on others to meet your needs. Next to each unmet need, write one or two things you could do to help yourself move closer to getting your needs met. Perhaps your therapist can help you identify things you can do to help yourself. Write target dates for completing the steps you can take.

[illegible]

_____	B.	_____	B.	_____
_____	A.	_____	A.	_____
_____	B.	_____	B.	_____

3. Write out the consequences of the actions that you have taken to help yourself satisfy your own needs.
